

Our topic today can be introduced by a question raised by Marilyn Adams:

“Suppose for the sake of argument that horrendous evil could be included in maximally perfect world orders. ...

Would the fact that God permitted horrors because they were means to His end of global perfection make the participant's life more tolerable, more worth living for him/her?”

The implicit assumption that Adams is making is that a good God would
make every human life worth living.

Suppose that there were some human being whose life was not worth living for him or her. Would a perfectly good being be justified in creating such a being, even if there were outweighing goods for others which could not be realized without his or her existence?



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox



evil & lives
not worth
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traditional doctrine of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with

Let's try to layout Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the

the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to

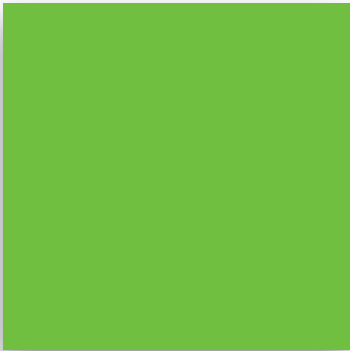
Let's call them the relevant properties.

open for what those properties might be; just have a name for them,

heaven and hell based on certain properties of these people. We will have



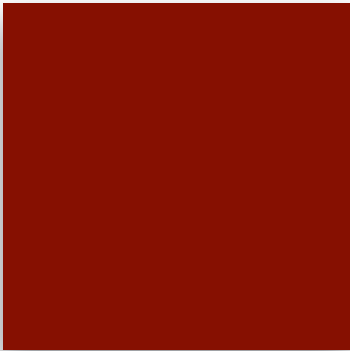










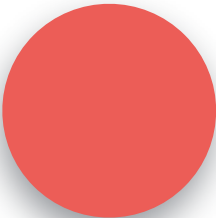




It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.

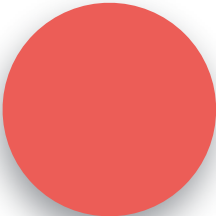






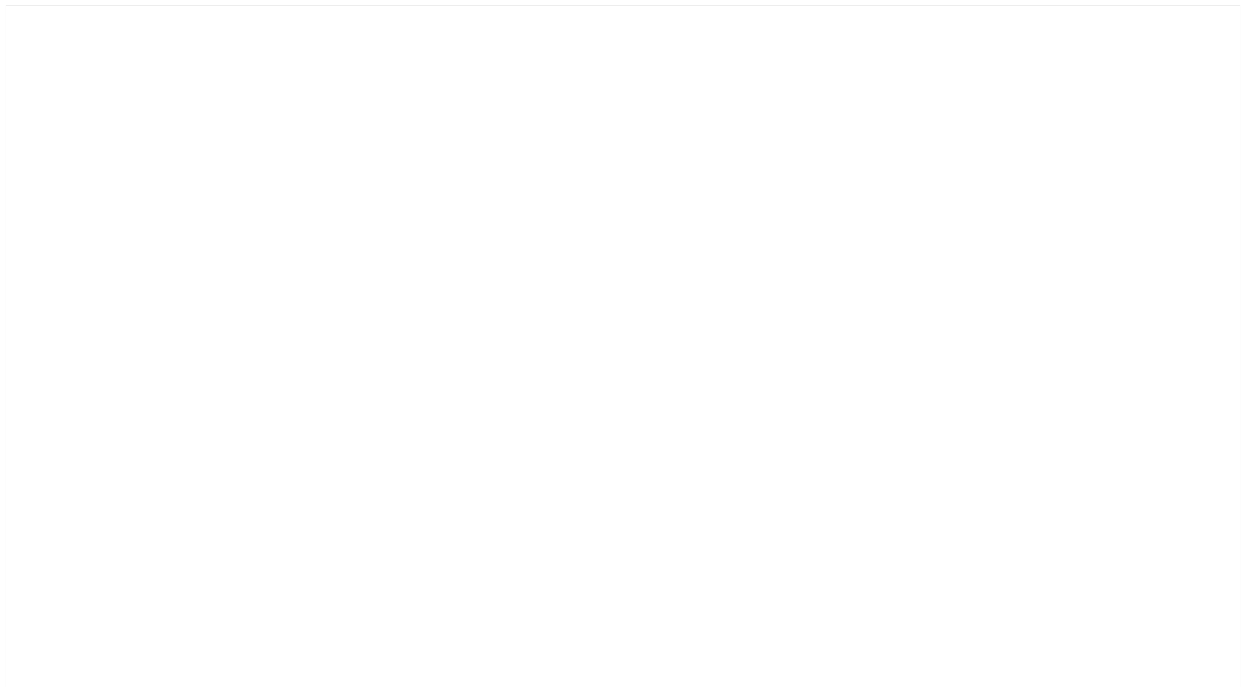
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describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:

The following passage from the *Catechism of the Catholic Church*



1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

into external punishment, but the rights into

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

eternis in die.

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

many of the major monotheistic religions practiced with the existence of a

perfectly good Good?



Before him will be gathered all the nations,

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

but the rights are all in it.

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

and the wild sheep are then from another

his glory, and all the angels with him . . .

the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

they will go away into eternal punishment,

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

got to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of



A large, solid red circle serves as the background for the text.

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